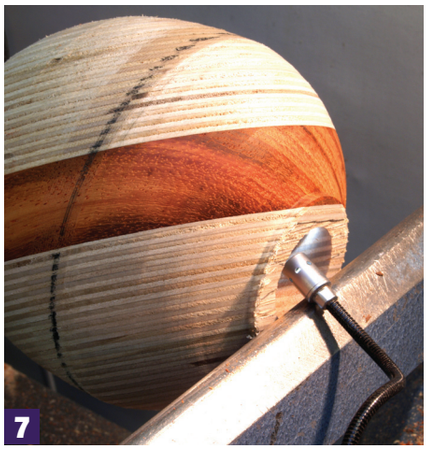
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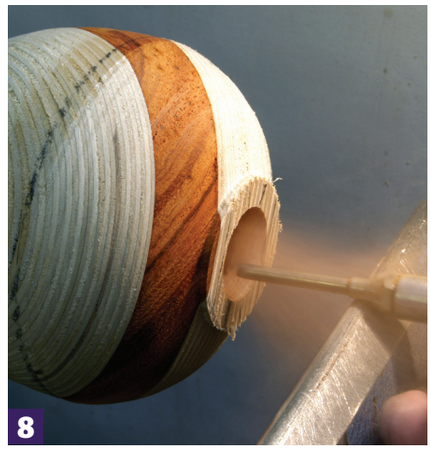
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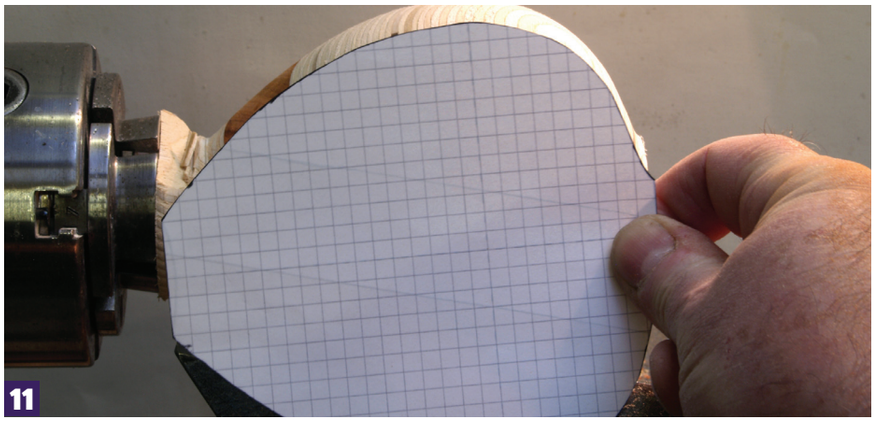
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7 A flexible LED lamp will help you see inside the hollow form, and between what you feel through the tool and what you can see inside, you'll develop a 'feel' for what is happening

8 I find a blast of compressed air is the best way to remove dust and shavings from inside the hollow form. Alternatively, try using a bent spoon to scoop out the debris or blowing through a straw but, if you do, make sure you shut your eyes first! Whenever I've tried using a straw I've found that the end gradually gets clogged up as dust sticks to the moisture from my breath. Because the gouge is scraping on its lower wing, and also because the glue in plywood blunts tools very quickly, you may soon tire of hollowing in this way and wish for a more specialised hollowing tool

9 I now use the Rolly Munro mini hollowing tool almost exclusively and find it very controllable in use. Its articulated head is excellent for reaching under the shoulder or to the bottom of a hollow form, depending on how it is arranged. The circular cutter can be rotated to a fresh edge when it dulls, and is easy to resharpen. However, there are alternatives and instead of using a shielded cutting tool like the one I use, there are multi-tip angled, swan-neck and articulated multi-tip hollowing tools aplenty. It doesn't matter what you use as long as it removes the wood cleanly, safely and it is something you feel comfortable using. Take steady cuts, starting under the shoulder and gradually working down the side of the form towards the bottom. Stop frequently to remove shavings and to measure the wall thickness with callipers. Note that I've rotated the headstock a little so that I don't have to lean over the lathe bed to get into the hollow form

Refining the external shape

10 With the hollowing down to an acceptable wall thickness, refine the shape of the outside with the bowl gouge

11 Continue to remove material from the outside until you achieve the desired shape. Referring to the paper template may help achieve this, but keep an eye on wall thickness – you don't want any accidents at this stage

12 Next, use a small 10mm bowl gouge to refine the shape of the opening before power sanding the whole of the outside, from 180 grit down to 400 grit

13 Plywood often has flaws and gaps in the ply layers and it is essential to examine the whole surface to see if you have exposed any. If so, carefully fill with a matching filler and re-sand the surface. Fortunately, the appearance of plywood is such that repairs almost always blend in and become unnoticeable

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